EPQ Shortlist: 20 Key Sources

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The 20 sources

If you read only 20 sources, read these. Each case study has three sources on its historical disruption and three on the present day, plus two for the method; 19 of the 20 are graded A or B. Numbers in brackets refer to the balanced Top 100.

#	Case and period	Source	Grade	Type	What it proves for the EPQ	Reliability
1	Hormuz, Tanker War	Navias, M.S. and Hooton, E.R. (1996). Tanker Wars (1)	A2	Academic book	The standard history: Iraq attacked shipping from 1981 and Iran from 1984, long before the US convoys. Backbone for incidents per year.	Reviewed academic book; dated (1996) and needs library access.
2	Hormuz, Tanker War	UN Security Council (1987). Resolution 598 (5)	A1	Primary	The binding 15–0 ceasefire that ended the Tanker War, though Iran took a year to accept it. Formal frameworks in Period 1.	Original UN legal text; shows diplomacy helped, not how much.
3	Hormuz, Tanker War	UPI (1987). Bridgeton hits a mine (11)	B1	News at the time	The first Earnest Will convoy was mined, with no minesweepers ready. The limits of escort cooperation.	Same-day wire report, widely confirmed; blaming Iran was a Pentagon claim.
4	Hormuz, 2026	IEA (2026). Largest ever oil stock release (21)	A1	Official	32 members released 400m barrels within 11 days. Best evidence for frameworks and response speed.	The deciding body's own announcement; written to calm markets.

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5	Hormuz, 2026	Lloyd's List (2026). Gulf war risk premiums topping double-digit millions per trip (28)	B2	Trade press	Premiums hit 7.5% of hull value against about 5% in the Tanker War, despite more cooperation.	Shipping paper of record; quotes brokers who gain when rates rise.
6	Hormuz, 2026	Kharroubi, E. (2026). BIS Working Paper 1378 (18)	B2	Academic	Hormuz disruption raises energy prices, then cuts output and lifts consumer prices after 4–6 months. Severity: prices.	Respected central-bank research; not peer-reviewed, snippet only.
7	Suez, 1967–75	Feyrer, J. (2021). Distance, trade, and income (38)	A2	Peer-reviewed	The closure cut trade, but less than older estimates said, because ships rerouted. Severity in Period 1.	Peer-reviewed economics; only the abstract seen.
8	Suez, 1967–75	Egypt–Israel (1974). Disengagement Agreement, UN S/11198 (42)	A1	Primary	Clearance began only after this political deal. The key counter-argument: politics, not cooperation, reopened the canal.	Original treaty text circulated by the UN.
9	Suez, 1967–75	CTF-65 (1975). Suez Canal Clearance Final Report (45)	B1	Primary	The US–UK–French clearance took eight months once allowed, after seven years of closure. Joint operations and response speed.	The team's own official record; a US self-assessment.
10	Red Sea, 2023–26	UNCTAD (2024). Navigating Troubled Waters (52)	A1	Official data	Suez transits down 42% and container transits down 67% by early 2024: partial, not total, disruption.	UN body's own data; an early-2024 snapshot.

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11	Red Sea, 2023–26	Lloyd's List (2024). Red Sea war risk rates jump after airstrikes (60)	B2	Trade press	Premiums roughly tripled within a week of the January 2024 strikes. Enforcement raised priced risk.	Leading shipping paper; broker quotes, baseline-dependent.
12	Red Sea, 2023–26	Tallis, J. (2025). Won tactically but failed strategically (59)	C2	Analysis	Navies won the engagements, but traffic never came back. The only source judging the coalition against outcomes.	A US analyst's argument, not data; kept because nothing stronger does this.
13	Malacca, 1999–2008	ICC-IMB (2001; 2006). Annual report releases (69)	A1	Official data	Attacks rose from 2 to 75 in 2000, then fell to 12 by 2005; the steepest fall came before the joint patrols.	Original data from a shipowner-backed watchdog; do not mix with ReCAAP counts.
14	Malacca, 1999–2008	Poonnawatt, K. (2023). From the RMSI to ReCAAP, Marine Policy 152 (67)	A2	Peer-reviewed	Why the US-backed patrol plan failed on sovereignty and information sharing worked better.	Peer-reviewed, single author confirmed; paywalled.
15	Malacca, 1999–2008	Al Jazeera (2005). Piracy disappears in tsunami's wake (74)	B2	News at the time	"The tsunami seems to have really succeeded where the joint patrols could not." The main Malacca counter-argument.	Major broadcaster quoting one official weeks after the event.
16	Malacca, 2023–26	ReCAAP ISC (2026). Annual Report 2025 (78)	A1	Official data	108 incidents in 2025, 107 in the Singapore Strait, mostly petty theft, at the height of cooperation.	Original data; voluntary reporting and a stake in looking effective.

#	Case and period	Source	Grade	Type	What it proves for the EPQ	Reliability
17	Malacca, 2023–26	ReCAAP ISC (2026). Half Yearly Report Jan–Jun 2026 (79)	A1	Official data	Incidents in the straits fell 74% (80 to 21), credited to coastal-state enforcement.	Original data confirmed by several outlets; the attribution is ReCAAP's own.
18	Malacca, 2023–26	MINDEF / Republic of Singapore Navy (2025). Reply on piracy in Singapore waters (88)	B2	Official	Robberies fell from 14 in July to 1 in September 2025 after Indonesian arrests; sets out the patrol and information-sharing machinery.	Official statement defending Singapore's record; counts only its own waters.
19	Method	Marin-Ferrer, M. et al. (2017). INFORM: Concept and Methodology (91)	A1	Official methodology	The model for R = (L × S × K)^(1/3), with cooperation as coping capacity.	EU Joint Research Centre method; built for disaster risk.
20	Method	George, A.L. and Bennett, A. (2005). Case Studies and Theory Development (94)	A2	Academic book	The standard guide to process tracing, which tests why risk changed.	Leading methods book; not freshly checked.

How the shortlist covers the question

Every case has evidence from both of its periods, and the counter-arguments are as well covered as the main argument.

Part of the EPQ	Sources (by number)
Formal frameworks	2, 4, 8, 14
Joint operations	3, 9, 12, 18
Information sharing	14, 16, 18
Response speed	4, 9, 13
Enforcement of laws	11, 17, 18
Likelihood (incidents, insurance)	1, 5, 11, 13, 16, 17
Severity (trade, duration, prices)	6, 7, 10

Part of the EPQ	Sources (by number)
Counter-arguments	3, 8, 11, 12, 13, 15
Method	19, 20

Mix	Count
Official, primary and data	10
Academic and peer-reviewed	5
Trade press and news written at the time	4 (plus 1 analysis)
Grade A / B / C	12 / 7 / 1

The one C-graded source, Tallis, stays because it is the only after-the-event judgement of the Red Sea coalition. Grades and reliability notes are unchanged from the Top 100; check every figure at its source before citing it.